

SLOANE

—ANCHORITE VANGUARD · EXILED · SIXTEEN · ALONE

AT THE EDGE OF
THE ZENITH PLATES,
ONLY DISCIPLINE
KEEPS YOU UPRIGHT.



A FALLEN CADET.
A FORBIDDEN EDGE.

NO RANK.
NO ALLIES.
NO TURNING BACK.



ISSUE
001

ZENITH PLATES ARCHIVE

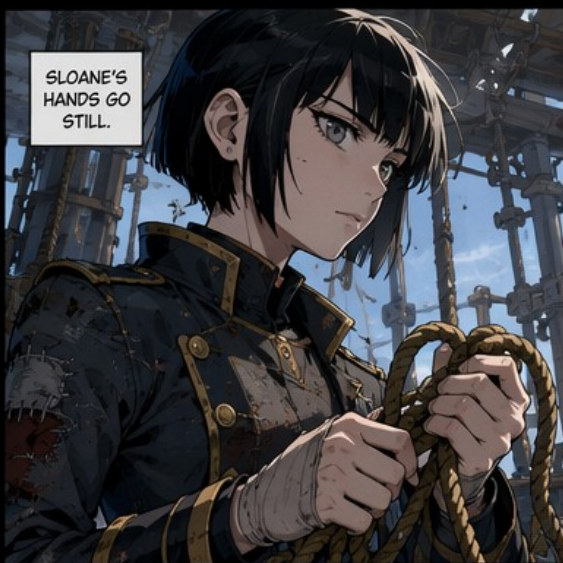


ZP-001-SLOANE

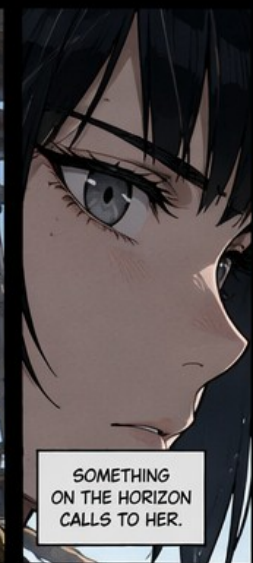
STORY AND ART BY
ZENITH ARCHIVES



THE AIR
GROWS THIN.
THE SKY
GROWS BRIGHT.



SLOANE'S
HANDS GO
STILL.



SOMETHING
ON THE HORIZON
CALLS TO HER.



HER POSTURE
STIFFENS.
STRAIGHTENS.
ALMOST
INVOLUNTARILY.



DISCIPLINE.
OLD HABIT.
DREAD.
ALL AT ONCE.

THE ZENITH
PLATES.
PERFECT.
SYMMETRICAL.
TERRIBLE.



YOU SEEIN'
WHAT I'M
SEEIN', BIX?

I-I THINK SO!

THE ALTITUDE
READINGS ARE
OFF THE CHARTS!



HEH.
WE'RE
ALMOST
THERE.

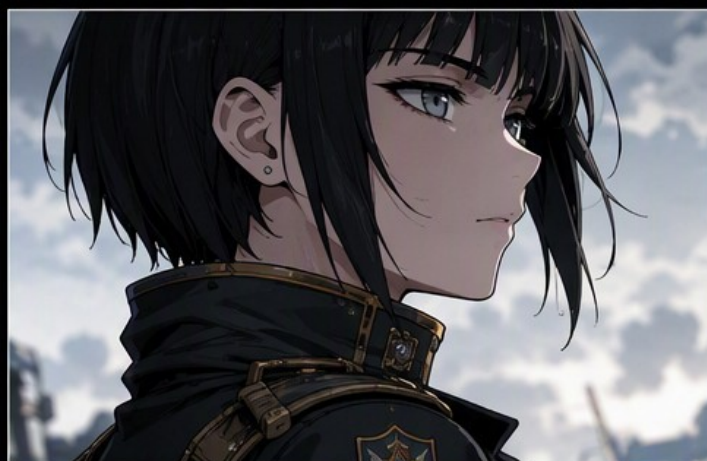
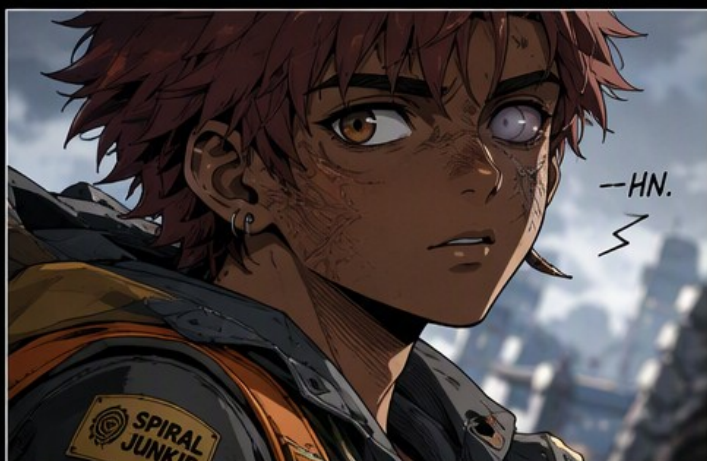
LET'S
GET THIS
PRETTY BIRD
PARKED.

ZENITH
PLATES.

SEVEN KILOMETERS
OF STOLEN SKY,
COMING DOWN.

SLOW.
INEVITABLE.

AND THERE'S
NOWHERE LEFT
TO CLIMB.



DECK QUIETS.
ENGINES HUM
LIKE HELD BREATH.

WE WAIT FOR
IMPACT.

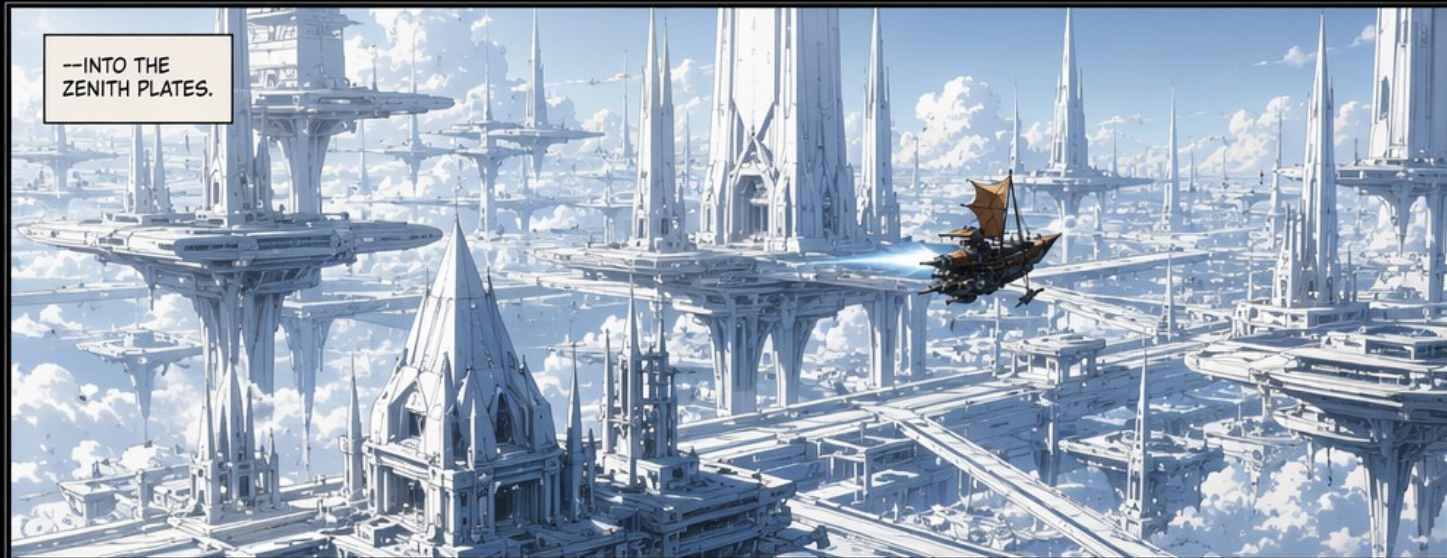




BEYOND THE TANGLE--
LIES THE HEIGHT
OF ORDER.



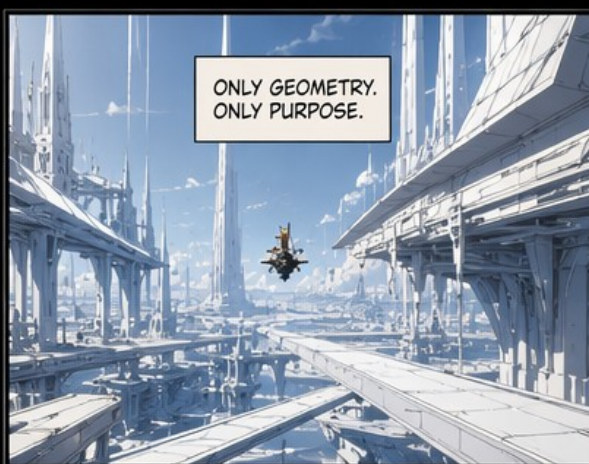
THE SWING-CLIPPER
PASSES THROUGH THE
BOUNDARY--



--INTO THE
ZENITH PLATES.



NO CHAOS.
NO THORNS.
NO VOICES.

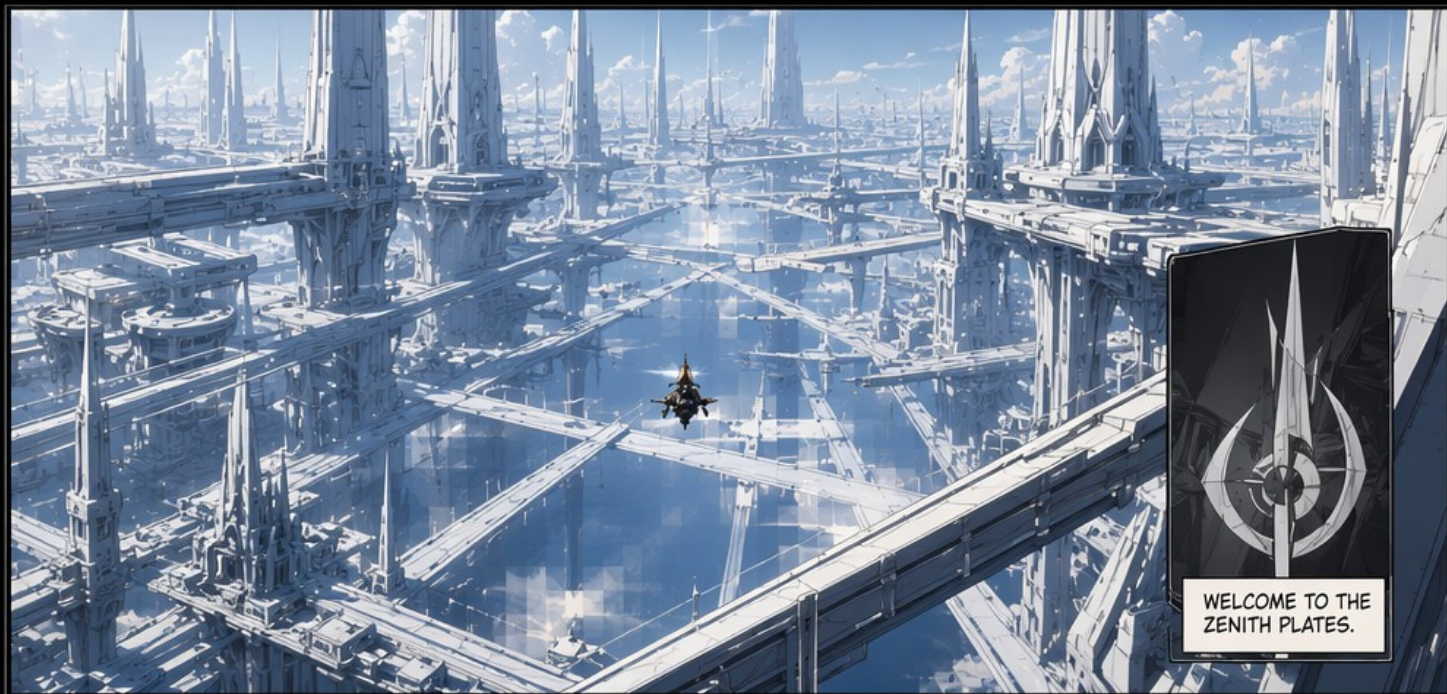


ONLY GEOMETRY.
ONLY PURPOSE.



THIS PLACE
DOESN'T JUST
TOUCH THE SKY...

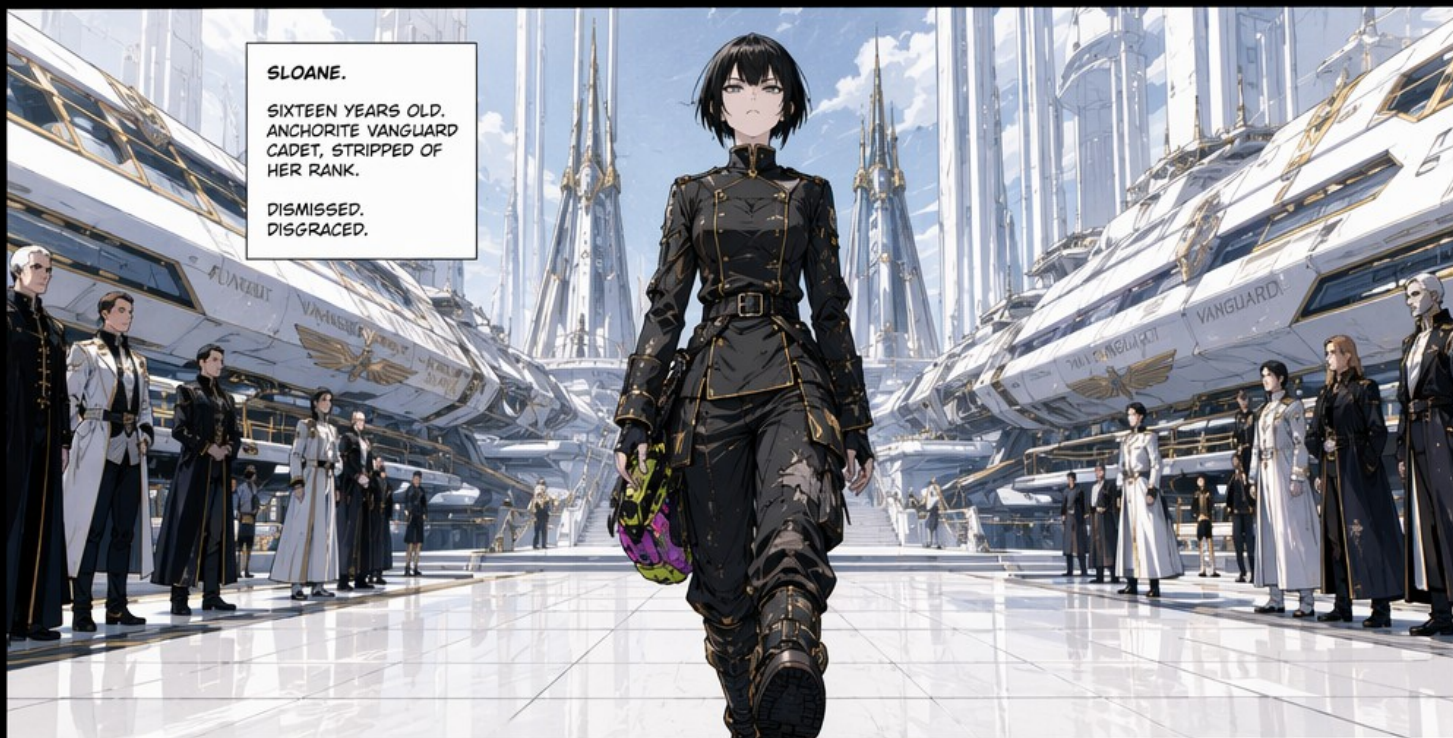
...IT
CORRECTS
IT.



WELCOME TO THE
ZENITH PLATES.

ZENITH DOCKS

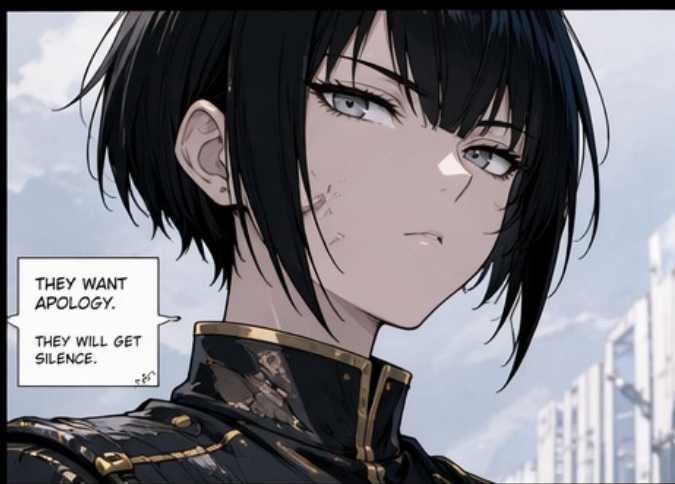
ANCHORITE VANGUARD FLEET



SLOANE.

SIXTEEN YEARS OLD.
ANCHORITE VANGUARD
CADET, STRIPPED OF
HER RANK.

DISMISSED.
DISGRACED.



THEY WANT
APOLOGY.

THEY WILL GET
SILENCE.



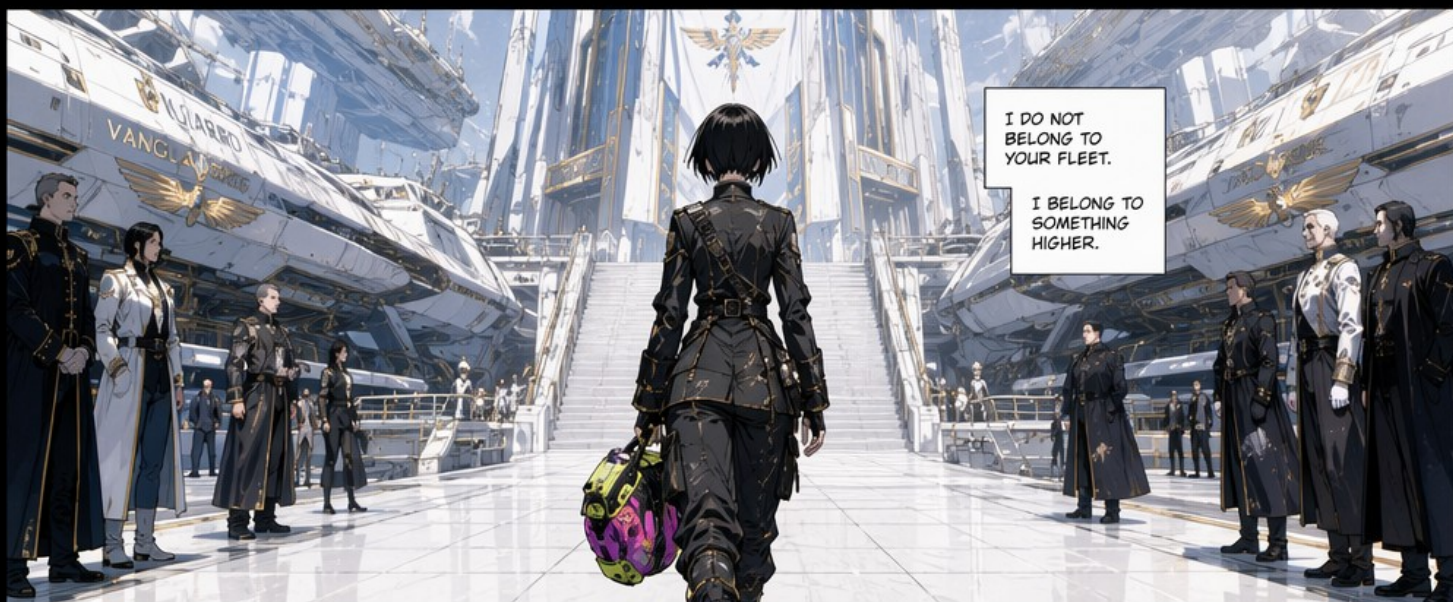
HOW POORLY THEY
HIDE THEIR DISTASTE.

HOW
PREDICTABLE.



LET THEM
REMEMBER.

I WAS HERE.



I DO NOT
BELONG TO
YOUR FLEET.

I BELONG TO
SOMETHING
HIGHER.

THE ANCHORITE
VANGUARD DOES
NOT KNEEL.

IT STANDS.
EVEN IN RUIN.

BY BLOOD
AND BY BINDING.

BY VOW AND
BY VOID.

I, SLOANE
OF HOUSE
VIRELLION,

REMAIN.

YOU STAND
WITHOUT CREST.

WITHOUT
RIGHT.

AND YET
YOU DARE
TO SPEAK
OUR OATHS.

WHAT
REMAINS...

THAT YOU
CLAIM?

NOT HONOR.

NOT
PRIVILEGE.

NOT EVEN
MY NAME.

ONLY THIS.

MY
BINDING.

TO VANGUARD.

TO ORDER.

TO THE LAST
ANCHOR.

I REMAIN.

THE ANTECHAMBER.
OUTSIDE THE PARLEY
HALL.

...AGREEMENT
MUST BE HONORED...

...THIRD CLAUSE,
SECTION SEVEN...

...THE COUNCIL
WILL DECIDE...

...PRECEDENT
CANNOT---

...ORDER!
ORDER!

THEY ALL
SOUND LIKE
STATUES...

...

JUST
TALKING...

AND WE'RE
OUT HERE LIKE
STRAY DOGS.

FIGURES.

TAP
TAP
TAP

MURMUR
MURMUR
MURMUR

...

WHAT IF THEY
DON'T LET US
IN?

WHAT IF
WE SAY THE
WRONG—

BIX.

BREATHE.

WE'RE NOT HERE
TO IMPRESS THEM.
WE'RE HERE TO
MAKE THEM
LISTEN.

TWO KIDS.

OUT OF PLACE.
OUT OF OPTIONS.

OUT HERE ANYWAY.

ANCHORITE VANGUARD
COMMAND SEAT
HIGH ATRIUM CORRIDOR

THIRD FLOOR



THIS WAY,
CADET.

RENN HATED THIS PLACE
THE FIRST TIME HE SAW IT.

STILL DOES.

PARLOR
LUX AETERNA
V-317



TOO WHITE.
TOO QUIET.

TOO MANY PEOPLE
WHO NEVER HAD TO
CLIMB FOR ANYTHING.

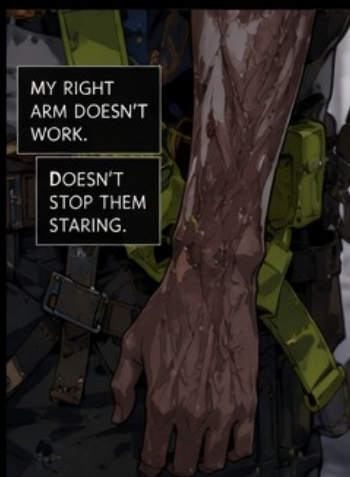


SLOANE DOESN'T
SEEM TO NOTICE.
OR PRETENDS
NOT TO.



THAT'S THE DIFFERENCE
BETWEEN SURVIVING
HERE...

...AND BELONGING.



MY RIGHT
ARM DOESN'T
WORK.

DOESN'T
STOP THEM
STARING.



TENSION-CRAFT
DOESN'T CARE
ABOUT HEROICS.

ONLY BALANCE.



THE COMMANDER
WILL SEE YOU
NOW.



PLEASE.
MAKE YOURSELVES
COMFORTABLE.

VANGUARD
PRIVATE PARLOR
BASTION SPIRE
HIGH HELIX

YOU BOTH HAVE
SHOULDERED
BURDENS MOST
WOULD CRUMBLE
UNDER.

AND YET, HERE
YOU ARE.

THAT IN ITSELF
IS... ADMIRABLE.

RENN.

YOUR
TENACITY IS
AS INFURIATING
AS IT IS
IMPRESSIVE.

HOW IS THAT
ARM HOLDING
UP TODAY?

...

IT'S
FINE.

SLOANE.

YOUR
DISCIPLINE
DOES YOU
CREDIT.

THOUGH I
WONDER...

KRIK

...HOW TIGHTLY
YOU CLING TO
PERFECTION.

YOU ARE BOTH
VANGUARD.

NOT BECAUSE
YOU ARE
UNBREAKABLE,

BUT BECAUSE
YOU CHOOSE
TO STAND
ANYWAY.

THAT IS
WHAT MATTERS.

SO.

LET US
PUT ASIDE
PRETENSES.

DRINK.

TELL ME
WHAT TRULY
HAUNTS YOU.

THE VANGUARD
DOES NOT SEEK
THE PERFECT.



IT FORGES
THE RESOLUTE.



RENN.
SLOANE.

I APPRECIATE YOUR...
UNORTHODOX ASSISTANCE.

VANGUARD PROTOCOL
DOES NOT HAVE A
SUBSECTION FOR WHAT
YOU DID.

SO WE WILL
WRITE ONE.



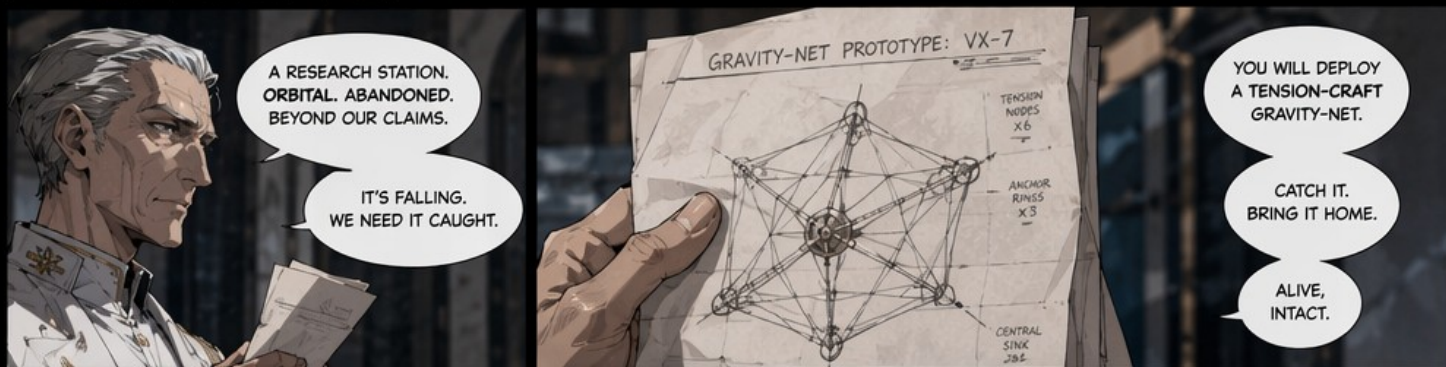
THE VANGUARD
CAN OFFER YOU
FULL PARDON.

I'M
LISTENING.

YOUR RECORDS
SEALED. YOUR
DEBTS CANCELLED.

IN RETURN... YOU
WILL DO SOMETHING
THE VANGUARD
CANNOT.

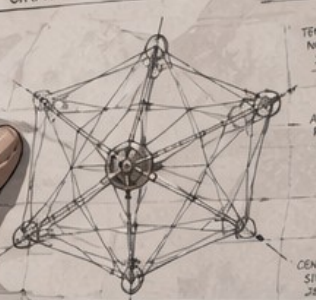
...



A RESEARCH STATION.
ORBITAL. ABANDONED.
BEYOND OUR CLAIMS.

IT'S FALLING.
WE NEED IT CAUGHT.

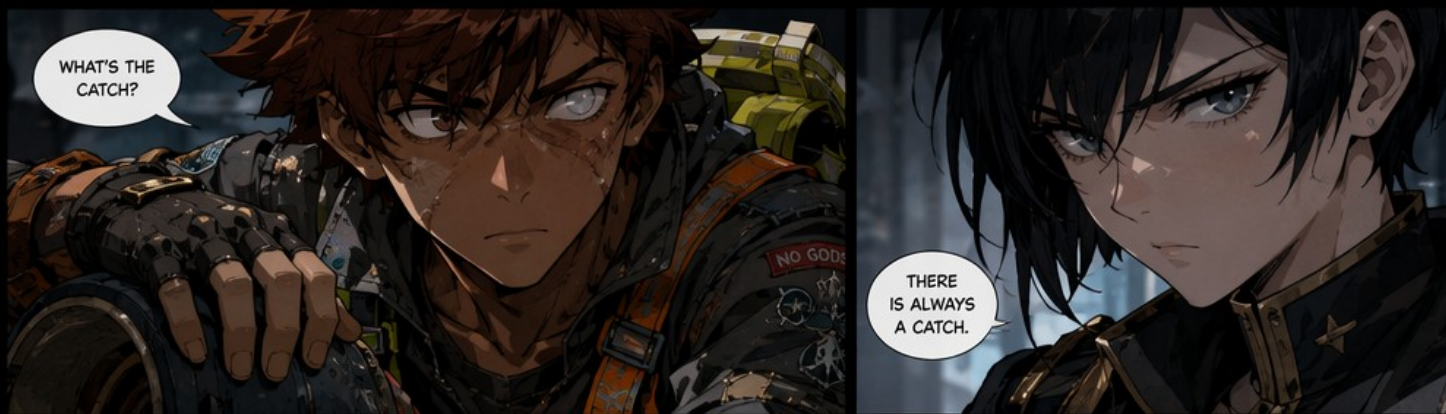
GRAVITY-NET PROTOTYPE: VX-7



YOU WILL DEPLOY
A TENSION-CRAFT
GRAVITY-NET.

CATCH IT.
BRING IT HOME.

ALIVE,
INTACT.



WHAT'S THE
CATCH?

THERE
IS ALWAYS
A CATCH.



NOT THIS TIME.

JUST A BARGAIN.
FAIR. AND MUTUALLY
BENEFICIAL.



VANGUARD PARLOR
THIRD SPHERE, HIGH ANCHOR

Ah, Renn.
You continue to
exceed even our
most optimistic
projections.

Such potential
should never be
hindered by...
unnecessary
limitations.

You'll allow
our artisans to
remedy that,
won't you?

...

Of course.
This is merely
an offer.

A gift, from
the Vanguard,
for one of its
brightest
climbers.

To give you
the freedom
to reach even
higher.

Please.
Allow us.

It's remarkable
how it measures you.
Full range of motion.
Tension-responsive.
Indistinguishable
from natural.

You'd scarcely
notice the
difference.

SLOANE TOOK
A HALF STEP
CLOSER.

NOT ENOUGH
TO TOUCH.

ENOUGH TO
MAKE HER
STANCE
CLEAR.

RENN'S
EXPRESSION
TIGHTENED.

ALMOST
IMPERCEPTIBLY.

HIS SCARRED
HAND CURLED
SLIGHTLY
INWARD.

SLOANE'S
EYES FLICKED
TO THE
ATTENDANTS.

THEN BACK
TO HIM.

UNBLINKING.

RENN'S GOOD
EYE MET HERS.

A FLICKER OF
MISCHIEF.

A PROMISE.

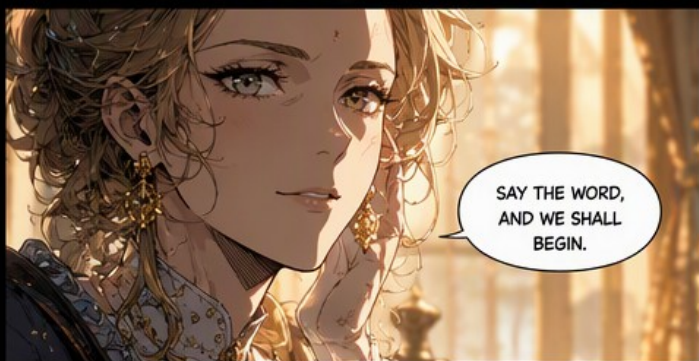


RENN, DEAR, YOU MUST
ACCEPT THE TREATMENT.
IT WOULD BE SUCH A PITY
TO WASTE YOUR...TALENTS.

THEY THINK SILENCE
IS SHYNESS.



THEY THINK
SILENCE CAN
BE PERSUADED.



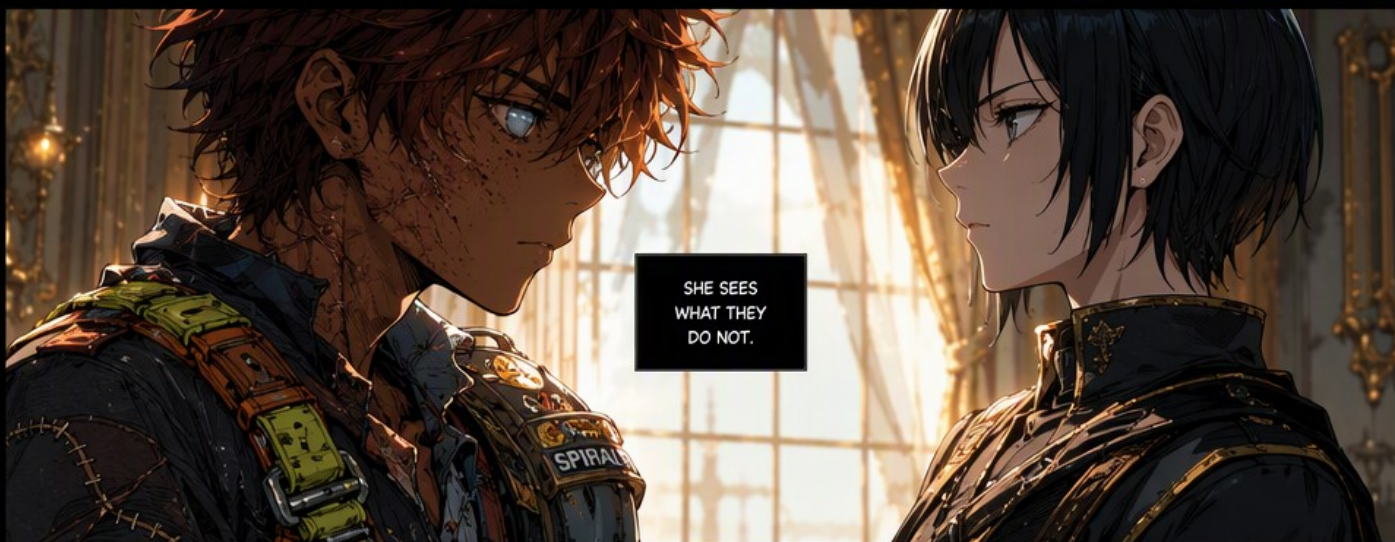
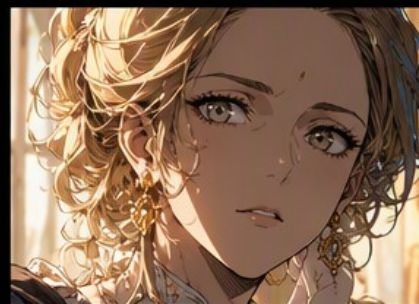
SAY THE WORD,
AND WE SHALL
BEGIN.



THEY ARE
MISTAKEN.



ONE PERSON
IS NOT.



SHE SEES
WHAT THEY
DO NOT.



...SO YOU
REFUSE, THEN?

THINK CAREFULLY,
GIRL. THERE ARE NO
SECOND CHANCES
OUTSIDE THESE
WALLS.

AFTER ALL WE
HAVE PROVIDED?



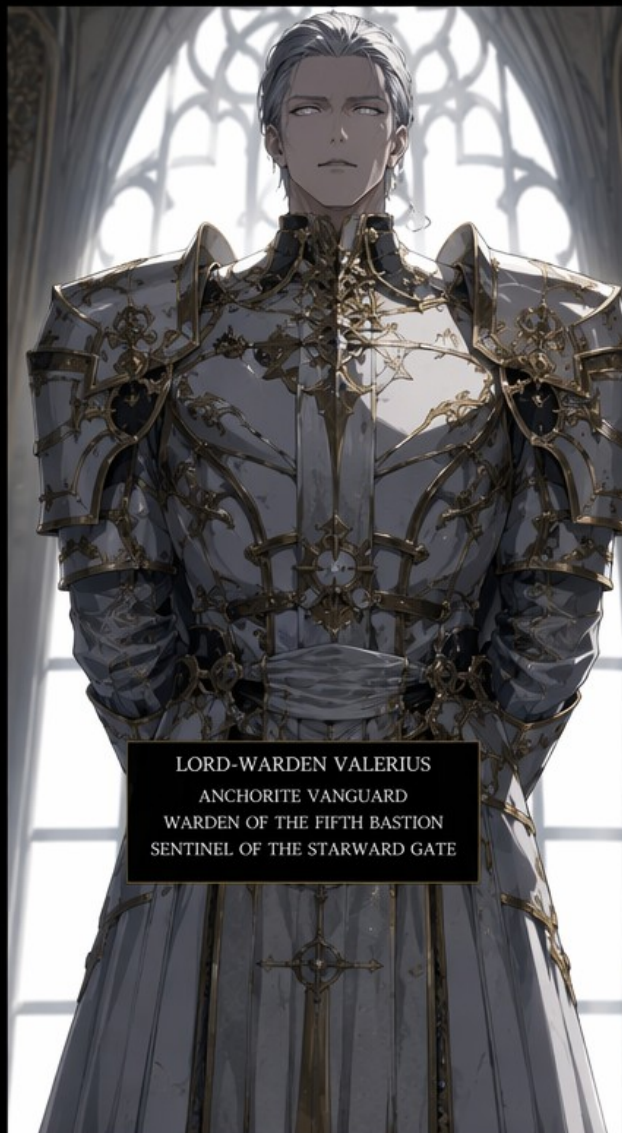
I DON'T NEED
YOUR CHARITY.

I WOULD RATHER
STARVE OUT THERE
THAN WEAR YOUR
COLORS AGAIN.



HAH!
SUCH PRIDE.

AND WHAT
WILL PRIDE FEED
YOU, I WONDER?



LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS
ANCHORITE VANGUARD
WARDEN OF THE FIFTH BASTION
SENTINEL OF THE STARWARD GATE



...HM.

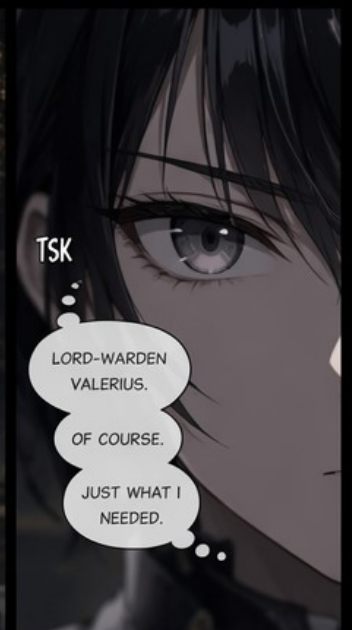
SO THIS IS HOW
THEY CHOOSE TO
TURN AWAY THEIR
OWN.

PUZZLING.



SLOANE

FORMER CADET, THIRD CIRCLE
ANCHORITE VANGUARD

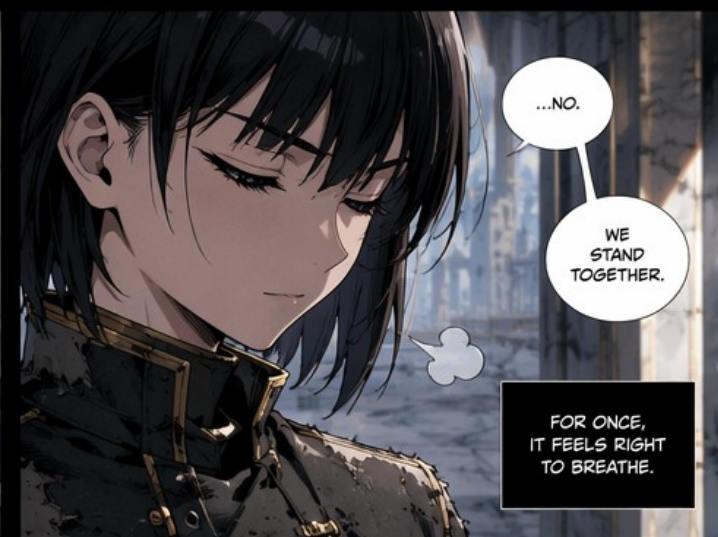
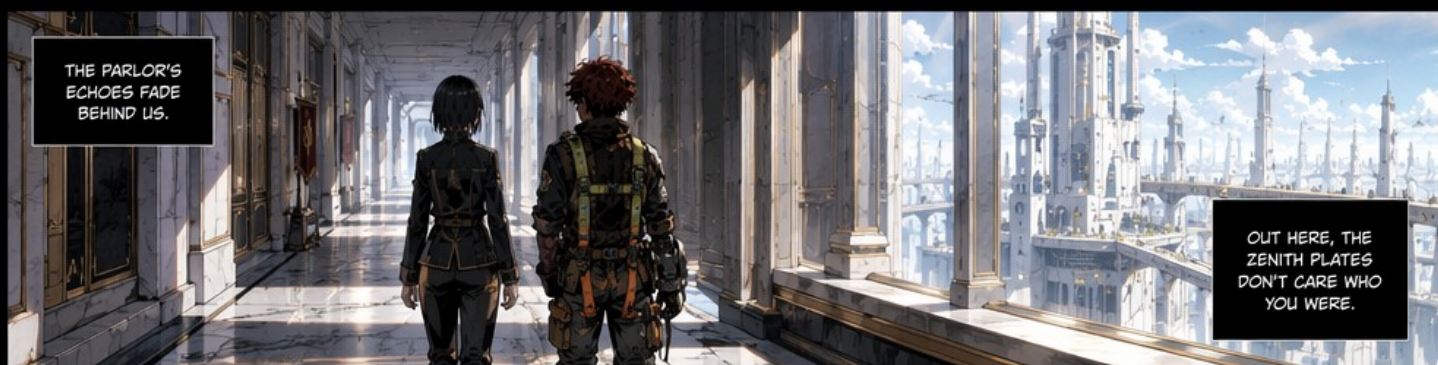


TSK

LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS.

OF COURSE.

JUST WHAT I
NEEDED.





I RETURNED
TO THE ONLY PLACE
THAT WAS EVER
TRULY MINE.



EVERYTHING EXACTLY
AS I LEFT IT.



NO DUST.
NO CHANGE.
NO ME.

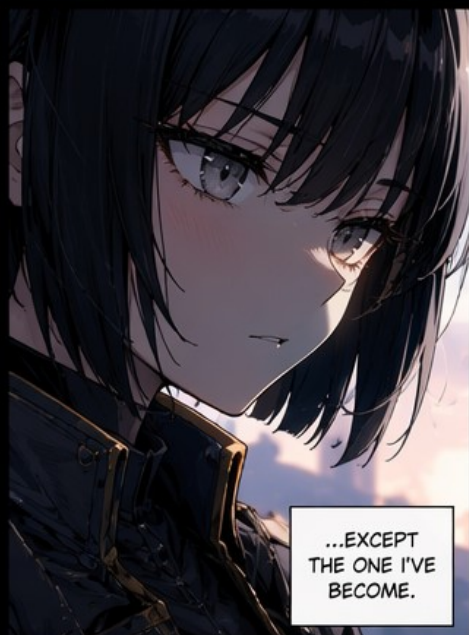


THE BED I MADE
EVERY MORNING.

THE COVERLET
I STITCHED BY HAND.



THIS ROOM
REMEMBERS
EVERY VERSION
OF ME...



...EXCEPT
THE ONE I'VE
BECOME.



DISCIPLINE
DOES NOT
PREPARE YOU
FOR SILENCE.

EPISODE XII: EXILE
CLOSING



SLOANE.
SIXTEEN YEARS OLD.

ONCE, SHE WAS
THE ANCHORITE
VANGUARD'S
FINEST CADET.

NOW SHE IS
NOTHING.



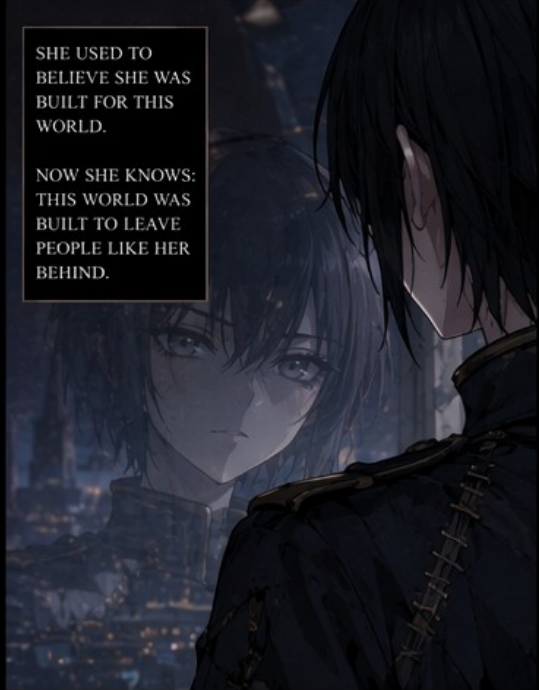
HER UNIFORM,
STRIPPED OF
RANK AND
HONOR.

RE-STITCHED
BY HAND.



THE ZENITH PLATES.
ETERNAL.
IMPASSIVE.

A THOUSAND MILES
OF ORDER SHE IS
NO LONGER PART OF.



SHE USED TO
BELIEVE SHE WAS
BUILT FOR THIS
WORLD.

NOW SHE KNOWS:
THIS WORLD WAS
BUILT TO LEAVE
PEOPLE LIKE HER
BEHIND.



SLOANE DOES NOT CRY.
SHE DOES NOT BREAK.

SHE SIMPLY...
STOPS HOLDING
HERSELF UPRIGHT.



AND FOR THE FIRST TIME
IN SIXTEEN YEARS...

SHE ALLOWS HERSELF
TO FEEL THE WEIGHT
OF BEING ALONE.

TOMORROW,
SHE WILL WALK
INTO THE UNKNOWN.

BUT TONIGHT—
SHE IS STILL JUST
A GIRL AT A WINDOW,
WATCHING A WORLD
THAT NO LONGER
WANTS HER.

TO BE CONTINUED.